Why Apple WANTS You to Touch Its iPhones

Recording script · read straight to camera · one section per take · stumble? pause 2 s and restart the line · pause ~1 s after each number

TAKE 1 **Cold open — the result**

Ever noticed that in an Apple store, every iPhone is out on the table, unlocked, just waiting for you to pick it up? That's not a favour. Apple wants it in your hand. Because the moment you hold it, it starts to feel like yours.

TAKE 2 **The question**

So why would thirty seconds of touching something make you pay more for it?

TAKE 3 **Why it matters to you**

Because it's happening to you every week. In the Apple store. At Decathlon. And on the shopping app in your pocket. By the end of this video, you'll spot the trap, and know the one rule that beats it.

TAKE 4 **Chapter 1 — The mug that doubled in price**

Think about a rented flat versus your own flat. Same walls. Same tiles. But the day you hang your family photo on that wall, a cracked tile stops being 'the landlord's problem'. It becomes my tile. Nothing changed about the tile. Only one thing changed. It feels like yours.

Economists call this the endowment effect. Once something feels like ours, we value it more. Because giving it up now feels like a loss. And our brains hate losses more than they love equal gains.

In 1990, three researchers, one of them later a Nobel winner, ran a simple test at Cornell University. They gave plain coffee mugs to half the students, at random. Then they asked: owners, what would you sell it for? Everyone else, what would you pay? The owners wanted about seven dollars. The buyers

offered about three. Same mug. More than double the price. Just because it was in their hands.

Now you might be thinking: maybe the owners just liked mugs more? That's the clever bit. The mugs were handed out at random. Owners and buyers were the same kind of students. The only difference was who was holding one. To be fair, later researchers showed part of that gap comes from how the test was run. But the effect keeps showing up, and it's strongest for things you can touch.

Here's the crazy part. You don't need to own it. You don't even need to hold it for long.

TAKE 5 Chapter 2 — Thirty seconds in your hand

So how long does it take for something to feel like yours? In 2008, researchers tested it with 144 people and, again, a coffee mug. Some held the mug for ten seconds. Others held it for thirty. Then everyone bid for it in a real auction, with real money. The thirty-second group bid significantly more. Just twenty extra seconds in their hands. And a second study went further. Simply touching a product makes you feel you own it, and makes you willing to pay more for it. Even when it isn't yours.

Now walk into an Apple store. Every iPhone, every Mac, every iPad is out. Unlocked. No security box. Staff don't rush you. Retail watchers say even the laptop screens are tilted to the same angle every morning, so you reach out and fix them. And it works. In 2023, each Apple store in India was reported to be selling twenty-two to twenty-five crore rupees a month.

Decathlon does the same thing, but bigger. Cricket nets. Football cages. Basketball courts. Inside the store. You don't just touch the bat. You hit three shots with it. And now it's your bat.

But wait. If touch sells so well, everyone would do it, right? Here's the catch: it's expensive. Decathlon India made over four thousand crore in revenue last year. But it posted a loss of sixty-five crore. Giant stores with sports courts cost a lot. So touch isn't free money. It's a bet that those thirty seconds pay for the floor space.

And this trick is so old, a government once warned shoppers about it. In 2003, the Illinois Attorney General in the US warned holiday shoppers: watch out for salespeople who ask you to hold the product and imagine owning it.

TAKE 6 **Chapter 3 — Your phone fakes the touch**

So what about online shopping? You can't touch a lipstick through Wi-Fi. Or can you? Think of it like a trial room mirror. The clothes aren't yours yet. But the mirror shows them on you. That's all online stores need.

The same study that showed touch builds ownership found something else. Just imagining you own it works too. And the researchers said it plainly: that's how online sellers can sell without touch. So apps fake three things. Touch. Use. And imagining it's yours.

Start with touch. In one study, people shopping on a touchscreen valued products about fifty percent more than people using a mouse. Your finger on the glass is almost a hand on the product. Then use. Myntra says its virtual makeup try-on doubled conversions in makeup. And in a survey for Snapchat, seventy-two percent of shoppers said they're more likely to buy after trying something on in AR.

And then imagine. Look at the words. Not 'cart'. Your bag. Your wishlist. Saved for you. The app is telling you it's already yours.

Now you might be thinking: if apps can fake it, why are shops still around? Because faking it has a bill. In Indian online fashion, around thirty to thirty-

five percent of orders come back. And over forty percent of those returns are about size. That's the cost of not letting you touch.

But here's where it gets interesting. Amazon shut down its 'try before you buy' service in January 2025. Warby Parker, the brand famous for posting you five frames to try at home, is ending that too. Both are betting that AI try-on is now good enough. The fake touch is replacing the real one.

TAKE 7 Chapter 4 — Its cousins: trials and DIY

The endowment effect has two cousins you've definitely met. One: the free trial. A month of no ads, and going back feels like losing something. One survey estimated seventy-two percent of Spotify trial users went on to pay. Same with a hundred-night mattress trial. After a hundred nights, it's your bed.

Two: the IKEA effect. Build it yourself, and you'll value it more. One study found people would pay about sixty-three percent more for furniture they'd assembled themselves. Effort is just another way of making it yours.

TAKE 8 Impact on you

So what does this mean for your money? The price you're willing to pay isn't fixed. It rises the moment something feels like yours. Thirty seconds with a phone. Three shots with a bat. One swipe. One try-on. And the brand designed every one of those moments.

Here's the one rule that beats it: the twenty-four-hour rule. Put it down. Close the app. Decide tomorrow. When you're not holding it, the 'mine' feeling fades. And ask one question: would I buy this if I'd never touched it?

TAKE 9 Spot it yourself + debatable question

Now you'll see it everywhere. The test drive where they say 'take it home for the weekend'. Lenskart and Nykaa putting the product on your face through

your camera. IKEA showing the sofa in your living room. The free trial that needs your card. And the words 'your bag' every time you open an app.

So here's my question. Is this smart selling, or is it manipulation? A: it's just good selling, you still choose. B: it's manipulation, stores should warn you, like Illinois did. Vote A or B in the comments.